Helping students manage independent study and preparation

Practical guide for subject lecturers | D13 S1–S6

Make independent work purposeful, manageable and connected to classroom learning. Students may need support with planning, study methods, English instructions or access to resources. Check the source of a difficulty before deciding how to help.

Contents

1. Make preparation specific and purposeful 1
2. Help students plan the workload 1
3. Demonstrate active study 2
4. Provide structure and gradually reduce support 2
5. Use preparation meaningfully in class 2
6. Build in reflection and adjustment 3
7. Supporting Sources 3

1. Make preparation specific and purposeful

Explain what students should do, why it matters and what they should bring or produce.

- Identify the essential preparation separately from optional extension.
- Provide focused questions and a clear location for materials.

Example - Business

“Read the case and identify two risks, with evidence. Bring brief notes to use in the group recommendation task.”

2. Help students plan the workload

Give a realistic initial time estimate and divide substantial work into stages. Explain that actual time will vary.

- Show the preparation alongside assignment deadlines.
- Ask students to flag tasks taking much longer than expected so you can identify the difficulty.

Example Engineering

"Allow around an hour initially: review the worked example, attempt two problems and note where you get stuck. Bring your attempts on Thursday."

Time estimates guide planning; they are not a measure of ability or a requirement to stop before understanding. Explain what students should prioritise if they cannot complete everything.

3. Demonstrate active study

Use course content to show a study method and explain when it is useful.

- Model recalling an explanation or solving a problem without consulting notes.
- Check the attempt against reliable course material and correct errors.
- Return to the learning later rather than concentrating all practice in one sitting.

Example Biology — Close the notes, sketch a process from memory, then check the sequence and add missing relationships in another colour.

4. Provide structure and gradually reduce support

When a task is new, provide a short checklist or planning guide. Model how to use it, then adjust the support in response to students' work.

- Begin with prompts for the important decisions.
- Ask students to explain their own approach as they become more capable.
- Retain or restore support where it remains useful.

Example Public health — Initially prompt students to identify a study's question, findings and limitations. Later ask them to devise their own reading questions.

5. Use preparation meaningfully in class

Design an activity that uses the preparation and makes its purpose visible.

- Allow a brief comparison or check before application.
- Address common misunderstandings and provide a practical way into the task for students with preparation gaps.

Example Economics — Students compare interpretations of a graph, clarify differences and use the graph to explain a policy scenario.

6. Build in reflection and adjustment

After selected tasks, ask students to review their approach and choose one change for next time.

- Ask what they planned, completed and learned.
- Help distinguish time, instructions, subject knowledge, English and resource access difficulties.
- Agree a next action or signpost appropriate support.

Example Environmental science — "Which part took longer than expected? What caused the difficulty? What will you change for the next reading, and what support do you need?"

Preparation and reflection template

Before the task	After the task
Task and purpose:	What I completed and can now explain:
Essential output and deadline:	What was difficult and why:
Planned study time and approach:	One change or support I need next time:

A short routine to try

Set one focused preparation task. Explain its purpose and approximate time, model a useful study method, use the preparation in class and ask students to identify one adjustment for next time.

7. Supporting Sources

Australian Education Research Organisation. (n.d.). *Spacing and retrieval practice guide*.

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